

The **בית הלוי**, in his introduction to **ספר שמות**, discusses a puzzling series of **פסוקים** in **תהלים** (105:24-26):

וַיִּפֹּר אֶת עֲמוֹ מְאֹד וַיַּעֲצִמְהוּ מִצָּרָיו: הִפָּךְ לָבָם לְשֹׂנְאָ עַמּוֹ לְהִתְנַכֵּל בְּעִבְדָּיו: שָׁלַח מֹשֶׁה עֲבָדָיו אֲהֵרֹן וְאַשֵּׁר בָּחַר בּוֹ:

The entire קה מזמור discusses the חסדי ה' which Hashem performed for כלל ישראל from the time of the avos through מציאת מצרים. Suddenly, in the middle of all of these שירות and תשבחות, we encounter a jarring פסוק: הפך לבם למצריים – “He changed the מצריים’s heart so they should hate us.” What טובה is being described here? On the contrary, it seems to diminish the גאולה, as it reveals that ה' caused the מצריים to hate us!

This raises an age-old question: How could it be that after יוסף and his brothers brought such fame and prosperity to מצרים, their descendants became עבדים overnight? The פסוק suggests that ה' was behind this transformation. Why? What עבירה caused this change of heart? Moreover, why is this point included among the חסדי ה' in this פרק?

- ב'ה' בָּגְדוּ: הוֹשַׁע (5:7) and quotes from sefer וַיָּקָם מִלֶּךְ הָדָשׁ עַל מִצְרָיִם (1:8) of פסוק discusses the מדרש רבה The  
 They raised, or gave birth to, sons - כִּי בָנִים זָרִים יָלְדוּ עִתָּהּ יֹאכֶלֶם הָדָשׁ אֶת הַלְלוּקִיָּהּ; ה' rebelled against כלל ישראל  
 the ברית - הָפְרוּ בְרִית מִיָּלָה; - בְּשָׁמַת יוֹסֵף הַצַּדִּיק When יוסף passed away; זָרִים who were מִפֶּר  
 Here we find out - מִכָּאן אֵתָּה לִמַּד שֶׁמֶשֶׁה מָלַן בְּיַצִּיאָתָן מִמִּצְרָיִם; מִצְרַיִם - אֲמָרוּ נִהְיֶה כַּמִּצְרַיִם; מִיָּלָה  
 the מִפֶּר - וְכִינּוֹן שֶׁעָשׂוּ כֵן; מִצְרַיִם who went out of them again when they went out of מִלְּמֶשֶׁה רַבֵּינוּ had to  
 caused מִצְרַיִם to start to hate them; ה' - הִפָּךְ הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים שֶׁהָיוּ הַמִּצְרַיִם אוֹהֲבִין אוֹתָן לְשֹׂנְאָה; בְּרִית  
 הַתִּנְכַּל - הַפָּךְ הַקְדוּשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים שֶׁהָיוּ הַמִּצְרַיִם אוֹהֲבִין אוֹתָן לְשֹׂנְאָה; בְּרִית  
 the פסוק we just said in - בְּעֵבְדֵי שְׂנֵאמֶר: הִפָּךְ לָבָם לְשֹׂנְאֵי עַמּוֹ

The questions are 1) What did כלל ישראל do? And 2) Why Hashem do this, what benefit was there to כלל ישראל?

The delves deeper into this מדרש. He notes that the act of being מִזֵּר the ברית מילה does not mean they stopped performing it. On the contrary, they continued to do מילה but followed it with מְשִׁיכָה, a practice of pulling the skin to recreate the appearance of an ערלה. This deceptive act allowed them to outwardly resemble the מצריים while technically fulfilling the מצוה. Their intent was to assimilate while still complying with the הלכה. This decision stemmed from a flawed calculation. Fearing their distinction as Jews would bring animosity, they sought to blend in. Yet, they misunderstood the profound significance of ברית מילה: it is not merely a physical act but a declaration of separateness, of being the נבחר עם. In response, Hashem intervened as an act of חסד. If כלל ישראל would not maintain their separateness, He would ensure it. By turning the hearts of the מצרים to hate them, Hashem preserved the distinction between His people and the nations. This separation was essential for our survival as a unique nation, both then and now.

מצרים, they asked the מצרים left בני ישראל. As פרשת בא פסוק further points to a remarkable בית הלווי for their valuables (12:34): וַיִּשְׁאַלּוּ מִצְרַיִם כָּלִי כֶסֶף וְכָלִי זָהָב וַיִּשְׁמְלוּ: One would expect the מצריים to begrudgingly comply or resentfully part with their belongings. Yet the next פסוק reveals: וְהַיְיָ נָתַן אֶת חֶן הָעָם בְּעֵינֵי מִצְרַיִם וַיִּשְׁאַלּוּם: Despite the devastation of מכת בכורות, בני ישראל found favor with the מצריים. How could this be? The answer lies in Hashem's control over events. Once כלל ישראל separated themselves by performing the פסח, the שְׁנֵאָה of the מצריים was no longer required. The פסוק is showing us that the whole purpose of giving the מצריים this שְׁנֵאָה was to keep us as the הנבחר, to keep us separate. Bezras Hashem, we should keep doing all of our מצות especially מילה ברית. We should have many more of them in our family, we should have a lot of שמחות, and we should see the גאולה שלמה במהרה! בימינו אמן!

